

Conversion Recipe: testthat to tinytest

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Table of contents

1	Conversion Recipe: testthat to tinytest	1
1.1	1. Layout	2
1.2	2. Bootstrap files	2
1.3	3. Single test_that block	2
1.4	4. Multiple test_that blocks per file	3
1.5	5. Shared fixtures	4
1.6	6. skip_on_cran and skip_if_not_installed	4
1.7	7. expect_error with class matching	5
1.8	8. expect_warning and expect_message with regex	5
1.9	9. expect_snapshot (no direct port)	6
1.10	10. expect_silent	7
1.11	11. expect_output	7
1.12	12. Assertions in testthat but not in tinytest	7
1.13	13. local_edition and edition_get	11
1.14	14. Parameterised tests	11
1.15	15. tolerance defaults	11
1.16	16. DESCRIPTION	12
1.17	17. Continuous integration	12
1.18	18. Coverage reporting	13
1.19	19. Running tests interactively	13
1.20	20. Visibility of non-exported package objects	13
1.21	21. Migration order	14
1.22	22. When not to convert	15

1 Conversion Recipe: testthat to tinytest

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This document is the reference companion to the post ‘From testthat to tinytest’. The body of the post argues the trade-offs; this document is the mechanical reference. Each section is a paired before-and-after example of a single `testthat` idiom and its `tinytest` equivalent.

The recipe assumes a package whose tests live in `tests/testthat/` with the standard `tests/testthat.R` bootstrap. The target layout is `inst/tinytest/` with a `tests/tinytest.R` bootstrap. See the post body for the rationale.

1.1 1. Layout

Element	testthat	tinytest
Test directory	<code>tests/testthat/</code>	<code>inst/tinytest/</code>
File-name prefix	<code>test-foo.R</code>	<code>test_foo.R</code>
Helper-file prefix	<code>helper-foo.R</code>	<code>helper_foo.R</code>
Bootstrap	<code>tests/testthat.R</code>	<code>tests/tinytest.R</code>
DESCRIPTION	Suggests: testthat	Suggests: tinytest
edition declaration	Config/testthat/edition: 3	(none)

1.2 2. Bootstrap files

1.2.1 Before: `tests/testthat.R`

```
library(testthat)
library(mypkg)
test_check('mypkg')
```

1.2.2 After: `tests/tinytest.R`

```
if (requireNamespace('tinytest', quietly = TRUE)) {
  tinytest::test_package('mypkg')
}
```

The guard makes the package buildable on systems without `tinytest` installed. Without the guard, R CMD check would fail on a system where `tinytest` is in `Suggests` but not installed.

1.3 3. Single `test_that` block

1.3.1 Before

```
# tests/testthat/test-arithmetic.R
test_that('addition works', {
  expect_equal(1 + 1, 2)
  expect_equal(2 + 2, 4)
  expect_true(is.numeric(1 + 1))
})
```

1.3.2 After

```
# inst/tinytest/test_arithmetic.R
expect_equal(1 + 1, 2)
expect_equal(2 + 2, 4)
expect_true(is.numeric(1 + 1))
```

The `test_that()` wrapper, the description string, and the braces all disappear. The three assertions are now top-level calls in the file. Test reports identify each assertion by its file name and line number.

1.4 4. Multiple `test_that` blocks per file

1.4.1 Before

```
# tests/testthat/test-arithmetic.R
test_that('addition works', {
  expect_equal(1 + 1, 2)
})

test_that('subtraction works', {
  expect_equal(2 - 1, 1)
})

test_that('multiplication works', {
  expect_equal(2 * 3, 6)
})
```

1.4.2 After (Option A: single file)

```
# inst/tinytest/test_arithmetic.R
expect_equal(1 + 1, 2) # addition
expect_equal(2 - 1, 1) # subtraction
expect_equal(2 * 3, 6) # multiplication
```

1.4.3 After (Option B: split into files)

```
inst/tinytest/test_addition.R
inst/tinytest/test_subtraction.R
inst/tinytest/test_multiplication.R
```

Option B is more idiomatic when the three groups exercise different source-code concerns. `tinytest` provides no mechanism for grouping inside a file; cohesion is enforced by file boundaries.

1.5 5. Shared fixtures

1.5.1 Before

```
# tests/testthat/helper-data.R
make_test_data <- function() {
  data.frame(x = 1:5, y = letters[1:5])
}

# tests/testthat/test-summary.R
test_that('nrow is correct', {
  df <- make_test_data()
  expect_equal(nrow(df), 5)
})
```

testthat automatically sources files matching `helper-*.R` before each test file.

1.5.2 After

```
# inst/tinytest/helper_data.R
make_test_data <- function() {
  data.frame(x = 1:5, y = letters[1:5])
}

# inst/tinytest/test_summary.R
source('helper_data.R', local = TRUE)
df <- make_test_data()
expect_equal(nrow(df), 5)
```

The `local = TRUE` argument keeps the fixture's symbols out of the global environment. `tinytest` does not source helper files automatically; the explicit `source()` is the substitute.

1.6 6. `skip_on_cran` and `skip_if_not_installed`

1.6.1 Before

```
test_that('integration test', {
  skip_on_cran()
  skip_if_not_installed('database_driver')
  result <- run_integration_test()
  expect_true(result$ok)
})
```

1.6.2 After

```
# inst/tinytest/test_integration.R
if (!nzchar(Sys.getenv('NOT_CRAN'))) {
  exit_file('Skipping on CRAN')
}
if (!requireNamespace('database_driver', quietly = TRUE)) {
  exit_file('database_driver not installed')
}
result <- run_integration_test()
expect_true(result$ok)
```

`exit_file()` halts the current file with the supplied message recorded as a skip. The check is at file scope rather than inside an assertion; this is a deliberate design choice.

1.7 7. `expect_error` with class matching

1.7.1 Before

```
test_that('errors are typed', {
  expect_error(my_function(bad_input),
              class = 'my_pkg_validation_error')
})
```

1.7.2 After

```
e <- expect_error(my_function(bad_input))
expect_true(inherits(e, 'my_pkg_validation_error'))
```

`tinytest::expect_error` returns the error object invisibly, which can be captured for further inspection. There is no `class` argument; the manual `inherits()` check is the substitute.

1.8 8. `expect_warning` and `expect_message` with regex

1.8.1 Before

```
test_that('emits a deprecation warning', {
  expect_warning(my_old_function(),
                'deprecated.*use my_new_function')
})
```

1.8.2 After

```
expect_warning(  
  my_old_function(),  
  pattern = 'deprecated.*use my_new_function'  
)
```

tinytest's `expect_warning()` accepts a regex via the explicit `pattern` argument. `expect_message()` works the same way. The behaviour is similar to `testthat`, but the argument must be named.

1.9 9. expect_snapshot (no direct port)

1.9.1 Before

```
test_that('table output is stable', {  
  expect_snapshot(print(my_summary(mtcars)))  
})
```

1.9.2 After (manual reference comparison)

```
# inst/tinytest/test_summary.R  
out <- capture.output(print(my_summary(mtcars)))  
ref <- readLines(system.file('reference_output',  
                             'summary_mtcars.txt',  
                             package = 'mypkg'))  
  
expect_equal(out, ref)
```

Generate the reference once with `writeLines(out, 'mypkg/inst/reference_output/summary_mtcars.txt')`. On subsequent runs the test compares against the stored file. This is the most ergonomic substitute for text snapshots, but it lacks `testthat`'s automatic regeneration on review and the diffing affordances of `waldo`.

For binary or large outputs, store an MD5 hash:

```
out <- format_some_object(x)  
expect_equal(tools::md5sum(out), 'expected_hash')
```

For images, use `tinytest::expect_equal_to_reference()`:

```
expect_equal_to_reference(my_plot_object(), 'plot.rds')
```

1.10 10. expect_silent

1.10.1 Before

```
test_that('no message on success', {
  expect_silent(my_quiet_function())
})
```

1.10.2 After

```
expect_silent(my_quiet_function())
```

Identical signature, identical semantics.

1.11 11. expect_output

1.11.1 Before

```
test_that('prints expected line', {
  expect_output(my_function(), 'Result: 42')
})
```

1.11.2 After

```
expect_stdout(my_function(), pattern = 'Result: 42')
```

tinytest separates `expect_stdout` and `expect_message` where `testthat` uses `expect_output` for both stdout and condition messages. Migration requires deciding which output stream the test was actually checking.

1.12 12. Assertions in testthat but not in tinytest

A class of patterns the original draft of this recipe missed. Two real migrations (`zzpower`, 10 files, 602 assertions; and `zztable1`, 13 files, 564 assertions) turned up nine `testthat` functions whose names `tinytest` does not export: `expect_s3_class`, `expect_type`, `expect_named`, `expect_no_error`, `expect_lt`, `expect_gt`, `expect_lte`, `expect_gte`, and `expect_is`. Each requires manual substitution. The substitutes are mechanical but worth naming explicitly because forgetting them produces a deceptively-passing migration: when `pkgload::load_all()` auto-attaches the `testthat` namespace from `Suggests`, the `testthat` versions silently resolve, and the `tinytest` run reports no errors but undercounts assertions.

1.12.1 expect_s3_class

```
# testthat
expect_s3_class(x, 'data.frame')
expect_s3_class(ui_obj, 'shiny.tag.list')

# tinytest
expect_inherits(x, 'data.frame')
expect_inherits(ui_obj, 'shiny.tag.list')
```

`expect_inherits()` is a `tinytest`-native assertion with the same semantics as `expect_s3_class()`.

1.12.2 expect_type

```
# testthat
expect_type(server_func, 'closure')
expect_type(x, 'double')
expect_type(y, 'character')

# tinytest
expect_true(is.function(server_func))
expect_equal(typeof(x), 'double')
expect_equal(typeof(y), 'character')
```

For the ‘closure’ case, `is.function()` is more semantic. For other type checks, comparing `typeof()` to a literal string preserves the `testthat` assertion verbatim.

1.12.3 expect_named

```
# testthat
expect_named(results_df, c('effect_size', 'cohens_d', 'power'))

# tinytest
expect_equal(sort(names(results_df)),
              sort(c('effect_size', 'cohens_d', 'power')))
```

The `sort()` is necessary because `expect_named()` defaults to order-insensitive matching. If the `testthat` call passed `ignore.order = FALSE`, drop the `sort()` calls on both sides.

1.12.4 expect_no_error

```
# testthat
expect_no_error({
  result <- some_function(...)
  expect_true(is.character(result))
  expect_true(nchar(result) > 0)
})

# tinytest
result <- some_function(...)
expect_true(is.character(result))
expect_true(nchar(result) > 0)
```

`expect_no_error()` is a wrapper that asserts the block neither errors nor returns a particular value. Since any uncaught error in a tinytest file fails the file by default, the wrapper is redundant: simply unwrap the block. The inner `expect_*` calls remain as direct assertions. Note that removing the outer `expect_no_error()` also removes one assertion from the count for each block; this is the expected behaviour, not a regression.

1.12.5 expect_lt, expect_gt, expect_lte, expect_gte

```
# testthat
expect_lt(elapsed, 0.5)
expect_gte(speedup_ratio, 0.5)
expect_lt(memory_size, 1000000, 'Memory regression')

# tinytest
expect_true(elapsed < 0.5)
expect_true(speedup_ratio >= 0.5)
expect_true(memory_size < 1000000)
```

The four ordering assertions have no tinytest equivalent; substitute `expect_true` with the inline comparison. The optional message argument that `testthat` accepts as a third positional argument has no tinytest counterpart and is dropped (the failing line and value are sufficient diagnostics in the tinytest report).

1.12.6 expect_is

```
# testthat (deprecated alias of expect_s3_class)
expect_is(theme, 'table1_theme')
expect_is(output, 'character')
```

```
# tinytest
expect_inherits(theme, 'table1_theme')
expect_inherits(output, 'character')
```

`expect_is` is `testthat`'s older alias and behaves like `expect_s3_class`. The `tinytest` substitute is the same: `expect_inherits`. Note that `expect_inherits` works for both S3 classes and base R types because R's class system treats 'character', 'numeric', etc. as classes for `inherits()` purposes.

1.12.7 Argument-name differences in `expect_error` /

1.12.8 `expect_warning` / `expect_message`

```
# testthat (both names accepted)
expect_error(f(), regex = 'pattern')
expect_warning(f(), regexp = 'pattern')

# tinytest
expect_error(f(), pattern = 'pattern')
expect_warning(f(), pattern = 'pattern')
```

`testthat` accepts `regex =` and `regexp =` as named arguments to its condition-matching expect functions. `tinytest` accepts only `pattern =`. A textual rewrite must rename both.

1.12.9 Detection

Before the first dry-run, `grep` for the patterns:

```
grep -hoE 'expect_(s3_class|type|named|no_error|lt|gt|lte|gte|is)\b' \
  inst/tinytest/*.R | sort | uniq -c
grep -hoE '(regex|regexp)[[:space:]]*=' inst/tinytest/*.R | \
  sort | uniq -c
```

If the count is non-zero, fix them before running the suite. A `pkgload`-based dry run will report 'all ok' even when these calls are present, because `pkgload` auto-attaches `testthat`. The cleaner verification is to run with `testthat` detached:

```
suppressMessages(pkgload::load_all('.', quiet = TRUE))
if ('testthat' %in% .packages()) {
  detach('package:testthat', unload = TRUE)
}
tinytest::run_test_dir('inst/tinytest', verbose = 0)
```

1.13 13. local_edition and edition_get

testthat 3 introduced editions to manage breaking changes. `tinytest` has no equivalent. Calls to `local_edition()`, `edition_get()`, and `Config/testthat/edition` should be removed entirely; the resulting tests run under whatever semantics `tinytest::expect_*()` provides.

1.14 14. Parameterised tests

1.14.1 Before (testthat with patrick)

```
patrick::with_parameters_test_that(
  'arithmetic identities hold',
  {
    expect_equal(op(1, 0), 1)
  },
  op = list(`+`, `-`, `*`, `/`)
)
```

1.14.2 After

```
for (op in list(`+`, `-`, `*`, `/`)) {
  expect_equal(op(1, 0), 1)
}
```

Or, with file-level granularity:

```
ops <- list(`+`, `-`, `*`, `/`)
results <- vapply(ops, function(op) op(1, 0), numeric(1))
expect_equal(results, c(1, 1, 0, Inf))
```

The for-loop variant lacks `patrick`'s test-name interpolation, so a failing iteration is identified only by line number.

1.15 15. tolerance defaults

A subtle compatibility issue: `tinytest::expect_equal()` uses a tolerance of `sqrt(.Machine$double.eps)`, matching `base::all.equal()`. `testthat::expect_equal()` historically used the same default but moved to stricter equality in edition 3. Tests that pass under `testthat 3` may need an explicit `tolerance = 0` on the `tinytest` side, and vice versa.

To assert exact equality:

```
expect_identical(x, y)
```

To assert numeric equality with a custom tolerance:

```
expect_equal(x, y, tolerance = 1e-10)
```

1.16 16. DESCRIPTION

1.16.1 Before

Suggests:

```
testthat (>= 3.0.0),  
knitr,  
rmarkdown
```

Config/testthat/edition: 3

1.16.2 After

Suggests:

```
tinytest,  
knitr,  
rmarkdown
```

Three changes: replace `testthat (>= 3.0.0)` with `tinytest`, remove the `Config/testthat/edition: 3` line, and do not add a version pin (`tinytest`'s API is stable enough that a floor is rarely needed).

1.17 17. Continuous integration

1.17.1 Before (GitHub Actions, standard r-lib)

```
- uses: r-lib/actions/check-r-package@v2
```

1.17.2 After

The same action works without modification because both frameworks expose their suite through R CMD check. The one optional addition, useful for a structured per-test report:

```
- name: Run tinytest with structured output  
  run: |  
    Rscript -e 'res <- tinytest::test_package("mypkg")  
               print(as.data.frame(res))'
```

This step writes a per-assertion data frame to the action log, which makes failures easier to diagnose than the default R CMD check summary.

1.18 18. Coverage reporting

Both frameworks support `covr` without configuration:

```
covr::package_coverage()
```

`covr` instruments source files, not test files, so the choice of test framework does not affect coverage measurement.

1.19 19. Running tests interactively

Action	testthat	tinytest
Run full suite	<code>devtools::test()</code>	<code>tinytest::test_package('.')</code>
Run single file	<code>testthat::test_file('foo.R')</code>	<code>tinytest::run_test_file('inst/tinytest/foo.R')</code>
Run during R CMD check	R CMD check (auto)	R CMD check (auto)
Continuous mode	<code>testthat::auto_test_package()</code>	(none; use <code>entr</code> or similar)
Test the installed package	<code>testthat::test_package('mypkg')</code>	<code>tinytest::test_package('mypkg')</code>

1.20 20. Visibility of non-exported package objects

A structural difference between the two frameworks that the mechanical conversion does not surface until the migrated suite is exercised by `R CMD check` against an installed package. This section was added after the recipe was used on the `zzpower` package and the issue showed up.

`testthat`'s `test_check(pkg)` runs each test file with the package's internal namespace exposed. A test file can reference non-exported objects (helper functions, package constants, internal S3 methods) by their bare names, and they resolve correctly. `tinytest`'s `test_package(pkg)` calls `library(pkg)`, which only attaches exports. The same bare reference in a `tinytest` file fails with 'object not found'.

A common pattern in `testthat` suites is to assert the existence of a package-internal constant:

```
# tests/testthat/test-constants.R
test_that('constants are defined', {
  expect_true(exists('PKG_CONSTANTS'))
  consts <- PKG_CONSTANTS
  expect_equal(consts$THRESHOLD, 0.05)
})
```

Mechanically converted to `tinytest`:

```
# inst/tinytest/test_constants.R
expect_true(exists('PKG_CONSTANTS'))
consts <- PKG_CONSTANTS
expect_equal(consts$THRESHOLD, 0.05)
```

If `PKG_CONSTANTS` is non-exported, the converted file passes under `pkgload::load_all() + tinytest::run_test_dir()` (because `pkgload` exposes the namespace) but fails under `R CMD check` (which uses `tinytest::test_package()` against the installed package, exposing only exports).

Three remediations, in increasing order of intrusiveness on the package itself:

1. **Qualify the reference in the test file.** Replace bare names with `getFromNamespace()`:

```
consts <- getFromNamespace('PKG_CONSTANTS', 'pkg')
expect_equal(consts$THRESHOLD, 0.05)
```

This works without any change to the package and is the recommended fix when the object should remain internal.

2. **Use the `pkg:::name` triple-colon operator.** Slightly shorter than `getFromNamespace`:

```
expect_equal(pkg:::PKG_CONSTANTS$THRESHOLD, 0.05)
```

`R CMD check` warns about `:::` use in package code but not in test files.

3. **Export the object.** Add an `@export` roxygen tag to the source declaration and regenerate `NAMESPACE`. Use only when the object is genuinely part of the public API.

The diagnostic that distinguishes this issue from a real test bug: under `pkgload::load_all() + tinytest::run_test_dir()` the suite passes; under `R CMD check` (or `tinytest::build_install_test()`) the suite fails with ‘object not found’ for one or more package-internal names.

1.21 21. Migration order

A practical sequence:

1. Create a feature branch.
2. Install `tinytest`; add it to `Suggests`.
3. Create `inst/tinytest/` and `tests/tinytest.R`.
4. Convert one test file at a time, leaving the original in place. Both bootstraps run during `R CMD check`, so the suite is double-counted during the transition. Track the conversion with a checklist.
5. After the last file is converted, delete `tests/testthat/` and `tests/testthat.R`.
6. Remove `testthat` from `Suggests` and remove `Config/testthat/edition`.
7. Run `R CMD check --as-cran` and confirm no warnings.
8. Merge.

If the migration stalls (snapshot tests, IDE dependency, parallelisation), revert the branch. The original suite is preserved on `main`.

1.22 22. When not to convert

- Snapshot-heavy suites (more than five `expect_snapshot_*`() calls). The manual reference-file pattern is workable but noticeably less ergonomic.
- Suites that depend on RStudio's test pane for interactive use. `tinytest` integrates with R CMD `check` but not with the IDE test runner.
- Suites that rely on `testthat`'s parallel mode for acceptable wall-clock time. `tinytest` runs serially by default; the `cl` argument to `test_all()` provides a manual cluster, but it is less polished.
- Packages whose contributors are unfamiliar with `tinytest`. The migration imposes a small learning cost on every future contributor; for actively-developed packages with multiple authors, the cost may exceed the benefit.

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